childhood. It ended in late 1918 when the Austro-Hungarian Empire and Germany agreed to an armistice closing the war in victory for the Allies.

Although unlikely, Erich afterward encouraged (or created) the legend that his father took part in the Kiel mutiny – the revolt by German Fleet sailors in November 1918 which triggered the revolution, sweeping aside the monarchy and giving birth to the Weimar Republic. (In fact, in the final days of the war, Wilhelm was posted to Belgium before finally returning home.)

With Germany defeated, British troops marched into the bomb-shattered Rhineland in December 1918 to begin an occupation that would last a decade.2 In the Saarland, the Treaty of Versailles gave the green light for the French to reoccupy the area as they sought to recoup losses sustained during the war – especially after the destruction of the collieries in northern France by German troops. (Versailles had placed the area, which was formerly part of Germany, under the administration of the League of Nations for fifteen years.)

The Allied occupation – combined with an economic downturn – guaranteed Wilhelm's lot down the mines contained increasing degrees of misery. 'That's why,' said Erich, 'my father joined the communists because he saw them as the best representatives of the interests of the workers.' Evenings became a time of almost continuous political activity, given the fluid politics of the early 1920s. Reminiscing about those years, classmate Arthur Mannbar recalled, 'people usually met up at Erich's small, simple but beautifully clean house. And while the young hotheads passionately debated the work of their union, Mother Honecker was busy making sandwiches and coffee for the whole group.3 During a period of inflation, unemployment and militant political action, Erich Honecker never forgot experiencing the '100-day strike' in 1922, when unions terminated miners' wage contracts, leading to a mass walkout. As a young Pioneer communist, he helped supply the pickets with food and newspapers, and collected donations. Peddling another legend, Honecker arranged a lively account to be published in a 1952 edition of Junge Welt, the communist youth paper: